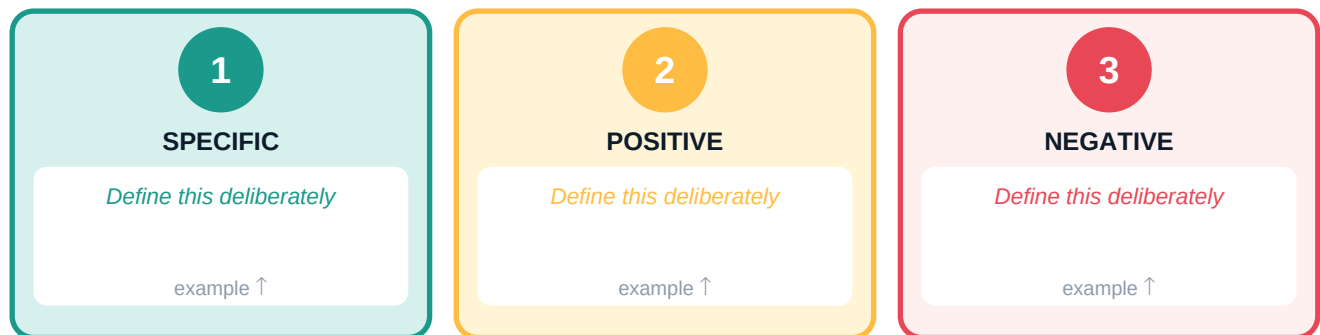


CHAPTER 7

Instructions That Actually Work



WHY MOST INSTRUCTIONS ARE TOO VAGUE Instructions are where most users put most of their effort, and still get disappointing results. The reason is usually not that the instructions are wrong. It is that they are underspecified.

"Make it more professional" is an instruction. But "more professional" in what dimension? More formal vocabulary? Shorter sentences? No contractions? Different paragraph structure? Fewer qualifications? More precise language?

AI will choose. And it will choose the version of "more professional" that appears most frequently in its training data for this type of text, which may not be what you meant at all.

Effective instructions are specific enough that a capable human could follow them without asking a clarifying question.

THE SPECIFICITY TEST Before sending an instruction, ask: "Could two different people interpret this differently?"

If yes, it is underspecified.

"Make it shorter" -> How much shorter? Half? A third? A specific word count? "Make it more engaging" -> More engaging how? More conversational? Shorter paragraphs? An opening question? Personal examples? "Make it suitable for our audience" -> Who is the audience and what do they need? "Improve the structure" -> More headings? Different order? Remove sections? Add an introduction?

Each of these pairs shows an instruction that fails the specificity test, and the questions that reveal what was actually meant. Answer those questions in the instruction.

POSITIVE AND NEGATIVE INSTRUCTIONS Instructions can specify what to do (positive) or what not to do (negative). Both are important. Most people use only positive instructions and then wonder why the output contains things they didn't want.

Negative instructions are particularly useful for:

Tone and register: "Do not use exclamation marks. Do not use filler phrases like 'I hope this finds you well.'" Content constraints: "Do not mention the merger, this is not public." Style: "Do not use bullet points, this should be flowing prose." Claims: "Do not make specific claims about delivery times, these vary by region."

A well-instructed prompt often includes both: "Write this in a direct, confident tone. Do not use passive voice. Do not hedge claims with phrases like 'it could be argued' or 'some might say.'"

INSTRUCTION TYPES AND WHEN TO USE THEM Different tasks benefit from different instruction types:

Format instructions, What structure should the output take? "Use a numbered list." / "Present this as a table with columns for X, Y, Z." / "Use three short paragraphs, no headings." / "One page maximum, A4, with a heading and four bullet points."

Tone instructions, How should it sound? "Direct and professional." / "Warm but concise." / "Technical but accessible, assume the reader has a science degree but is not a specialist in this field." / "In the voice of the existing document I'm attaching."



PART II - BUILD BETTER INTERACTIONS

Priority instructions, What matters most? "Lead with the cost saving, not the process improvement." / "The most important point must be in the first sentence." / "The client's concern about timeline is more important than the features list, address it first."

Exclusion instructions, What to leave out? "Do not include implementation details, this is for a non-technical audience." / "Exclude anything older than 2024, the reader will already know the history." / "Do not include a summary, the reader will read the whole thing."

Role instructions, From whose perspective? "Write this as if the reader has never heard of our company." / "The reader is a sceptic, address their likely objections before they ask."



THE BEFORE -> BETTER -> BEST: INSTRUCTIONS BEFORE

"Rewrite this paragraph to make it better."

[Paragraph: "Our team has extensive experience in the delivery of complex technology projects. We have worked with a wide range of clients across multiple sectors and have a proven track record of

delivering projects on time and on budget."]

Output: AI produces a slightly more polished version of the same paragraph. Same ideas, slightly varied vocabulary. The reader would not notice a meaningful difference.

BETTER

"Rewrite this paragraph to remove clichés and make it more specific and credible. Replace phrases like 'extensive experience' and 'proven track record' with concrete language."

Chapter 7 - Instructions That Actually Work

Output: AI produces a version that avoids the worst clichés and becomes more specific in tone, though it invents specifics it doesn't have.

BEST

"Rewrite this paragraph for inclusion in a proposal to a housing association considering a digital transformation project. The audience is a director who has seen many similar proposals and is sceptical of vague claims.

Instructions:

Remove all clichés: 'extensive experience', 'wide range', 'proven track record', 'multiple sectors' must all go.

Replace vague claims with specific patterns of evidence. I will provide specifics in a moment, for now, leave [BRACKETS] as placeholders for: number of years in the sector, number of completed projects, one specific client sector, and one specific result we achieved.

First sentence should establish relevance to housing sector specifically, not generic technology experience.

Maximum two sentences. Punchy, not promotional."

Output: A tightly constructed two-sentence paragraph that is specific in structure, leaves appropriate placeholders, and is pitched correctly at the sceptical reader.



WHAT CHANGED?



PART II - BUILD BETTER INTERACTIONS



INSTRUCTION ELEMENT WHY IT MATTERED

Audience specified Shaped the pitch level and scepticism antidote

Banned phrases listed explicitly Prevented the most common failure

Placeholder pattern Kept AI honest about missing specifics

Structural requirement (first Prevented the generic opener sentence)

Length constraint (two sentences) Forced concision

Tone instruction (not promotional) Prevented the default enthusiastic pitch

TRY THIS TAKE THE LAST AI OUTPUT YOU WERE DISSATISFIED WITH. IDENTIFY ONE THING THAT WAS WRONG WITH IT, TOO L

Write a follow-up instruction that specifically addresses that one thing,
using the specificity test: could two people interpret this instruction
differently?

If yes, refine it until the answer is no.

WATCH OUT INSTRUCTIONS THAT CONFLICT PRODUCE CONFUSED OUTPUT. IF YOU SAY "BE BRIEF AND COMPREHENSIVE," "

"Be brief, prioritise this over comprehensiveness if necessary."

Chapter 7 - Instructions That Actually Work